

WAGONER COUNTY ECONOMIC DEVELOPMENT AUTHORITY
MEETING MINUTES

City Council Meeting Room, City Hall – Coweta
Wednesday, January 17, 2024

The Wagoner County Economic Development Authority met in open meeting at the City Hall in Coweta on Wednesday January 17, 2024. The meeting was publicly posted at City Hall and on the county website on January 10, 2024. In attendance were all members of the authority with the exception of Brian Kuester. Secretary Lori Hendricks, County Clerk was also in attendance. New trustee Tim Conroy was sworn in prior to the meeting. Guests in attendance were Rachael Cooper, county engineer and Darla Heller, county Economic Development Director.

- I. The meeting was called to order by Chairman Chris Leffingwell at 3:05pm.
- II. The prayer was led by Lori Hendricks and the pledge was led by Norm Stephens.
- III. Financial Report – The Financial Report was given by Lori Hendricks. Additional discussion regarding investment plan was led by Chris Leffingwell. Based on this information, a motion was made by Norm Stephens and seconded by Orlin Emmons to move \$2 million to CD's at Armstrong Bank at 5.17% and BancFirst at 4/94%. The motion was approved with the following votes: Leffingwell, aye; Stephens, aye; Emmons, aye; Nicholas, aye; Conroy, aye; Kelley, aye.
- IV. Minutes – a motion was made by Steve Nicholas and seconded by Chris Leffingwell to approve the minutes. The motion was approved with the following votes: Leffingwell, aye; Stephens, aye; Emmons, aye; Nicholas, aye; Conroy, aye; Kelley, aye.
- V. New Business
 - A. Economic Development Director's Report – Darla Heller gave her report.

The Junction – Ms. Heller indicated she is staying involved to push this project forward including participation with the application for both USDA and State of Oklahoma grant funding.

Project Sunset – This is the proposed outdoor amphitheater in Broken Arrow. Hearings are currently underway and will go to the planning commission in April

Project Anthem – Committee meetings on the TID begin next week.

Highway 51 Interchange – Still in progress.

Consultants – Darla attended a recent meeting of consultants who are involved in site surveys for potential businesses.

She presented her updated list of goals for the role and the authority as it relates to events, partners and budget. Chris Leffingwell reminded the board that Ms. Heller works for the Board of Commissioners .

P3 Pooled Finance – Darla gave a brief overview of this program the county has elected to participate in. It is a way to fund public infrastructure using state payroll taxes.

No Action was taken on any item presented with the report.

- B. Presentation, discussion and possible action concerning county sales tax. – County Engineer Rachael Cooper gave a brief presentation on each of the ballot questions for the March 5th ballot.

Lodging Tax - 5% is pay as you stay for hotels, bed and breakfasts and RV parks in the unincorporated areas of the county. Funds will be used to pay for tourism, primarily focused on the JPC trail.

Existing 1.3% tax

.8 goes to roads and bridges and results in \$2.3 million plus per district.

Represents 68% of total funding for this purpose.

.10 goes to fund the operation of the Sheriff's office.

.10 goes to county general and is used to pay for insurance.

Permanency allows for bonding for any county project.

.3 Fire Tax is already permanent. Ballot would divert ½ to fund an ambulance service. Fire Departments currently receive \$16,000+ monthly compared to Cherokee County at \$5,000.

New measures

Courthouse Renovation/Repair - .125% for parking and pedestrian improvements at the Wagoner County Courthouse. Term of 30 years or \$10 million.

Wagoner County Criminal Justice Authority - .25% to fund operations of the jail. ACCO-SIF board suggests some protection against liability. Would be a Title 60 Trust. Fund would general projected \$2 million annually.

Fairgrounds - .125% for a term of 30 years or \$10 million to fund a new Fairgrounds. The Fair Board is currently negotiating for a land swap with the City of Coweta for property at the sports complex adjacent to the turnpike.

How does Wagoner County compare to other counties:

25 of 77 counties are at a tax rate of 2%

8 counties are at 1.75% or more

Rogers County is at 1.833 and Cherokee County is at 1.75%

- C. Discussion and possible action regarding funding for downtown Coweta project. – There is currently a bid out for renovations to the DAV building to include a meeting room. The cost is projected at \$240,000 Chris Leffingwell indicated that

if the Board of Commissioners pays for the roof (currently out to bid), and if the building is for public use similar to the Junction project, the authority wants to get behind it. Darla Heller shared that her vision for the building is as a co-working space and business incubator. With this function, it may qualify for USDA funding up to \$100,000. No Action was taken.

VI. Old Business

- A. Discussion and possible action regarding sale of 289th property. – Kristen Bell gave an update indicating that the deal with the developer has been rescinded. Currently 10-acre parcels are selling for \$10,000-\$25,000 per acre. Chris Leffingwell shared his thoughts on 10-acre plat waiver splits. County Engineer Rachael Cooper indicated that the authority could do 6 to 8 parcels with the statutory requirements that they be 300 feet wide on a section line but that they could not divide further, however another party could purchase and then divide again. She indicated that is a loophole in the regulation. Ms. Bell recommended an ask of \$17,000 per acre for those larger parcels. Norm Stephens indicated that the cost of land is not going down, that the authority has available funds so there is no hurry to divest this property. Tim Conroy asked for a brief history of the parcel and was given one. Commissioner Kelley expressed that he believes the authority should hold at \$20,000. No Action was taken.
- B. Discussion and possible action regarding agreement with the City of Wagoner Economic Development Authority on funding for Project Junction. – John Chandler spoke regarding the project. They are currently looking at architects for the project. Mr. Chandler spoke positively about Tony Lowe, formerly with the City of Wagoner Economic Development Authority who passed away recently. Chris Leffingwell assured everyone that the board remains committed. He mentioned a possible scholarship for students who may have a municipal focus to their studies to encourage pursuit of this field. He also mentioned that the authority should investigate possible business grants, perhaps 2 at \$2500 each to help new business and asked the board to be considering that possibility. Mr. Chandler shared some of their efforts with kids and grants. Business grants have been available through WEDA and were managed by the Lions Club.

VII. Public Comment – Lisa Taylor, interim City Manager for the City of Coweta gave an update.

The bridge on Eufaula Street is set for completion in Mid-March. They are expecting a change order to replace the water line to accommodate the new business coming in.

Wastewater Treatment received a \$30,000 fine and is obligated to begin corrections by May of 2024 and complete by November of 2025. They have the available funding.

Relative to the property on 289th, Ms. Taylor recommended that due to the current inability to serve the sewer and/or to collect on delinquent bills, the authority not entertain as high density as previously sought. Half-acre lots with the ability to accommodate septic are currently more appropriate.

- VIII. Adjourn. – A motion was made by Orlin Emmons and seconded by Steve Nicholas to adjourn at 4:34pm. The motion was approved with the following votes: Leffingwell, aye; Stephens, aye; Emmons, aye; Nicholas, aye; Conroy, aye; Kelley, aye.

Submitted by:

Lori Hendricks, Secretary

Chris Leffingwell, Chair

Orlin Emmons, Member

Steve Nicholas, Member

Tim Kelley, Member

Norman Stephens, Member

Brian Kuester, Member

Tim Conroy, Member